Assignment 1 – IPM/HCI

Interação Pessoa-Máquina (Human-Computer Interaction) 2026/2027

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Good example: assignment submission and the course page in Moodle

Objective of the interface

Moodle (at NOVA FCT, Moodle@FCT) is the e-learning platform where teachers publish materials and students read content, take part in activities and submit assignments. This analysis does not cover the whole platform, only two specific aspects: the course page, organised by topics or weeks, and the assignment submission screen, such as the one used to hand in this lab.

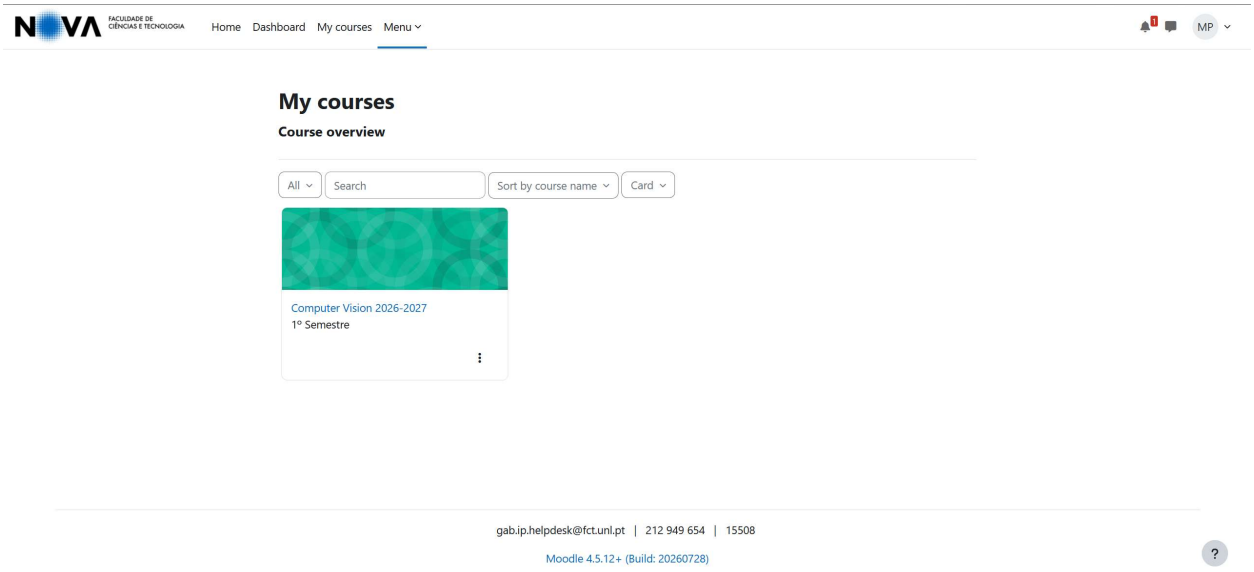
Good aspects

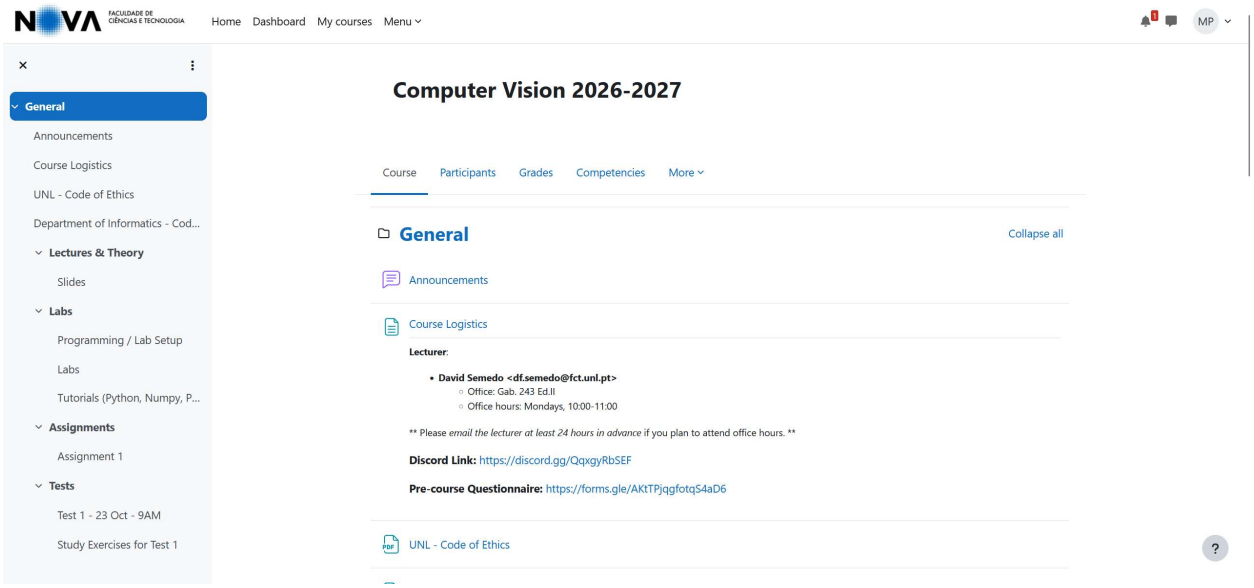
- The course page splits content into blocks (by week or theme) with a title, and each resource has an icon showing its type (PDF, link, assignment, forum).
- An assignment screen has a simple status table: submission status, grading status, due date and time remaining.
- Files are uploaded by dragging them onto a marked area or choosing them from the computer, and the submitted file is then listed.
- The status changes visibly after submission (for example to "submitted for grading"), and while the deadline is open the submission can still be edited.
- The timeline block and the calendar gather deadlines from several courses in one place.

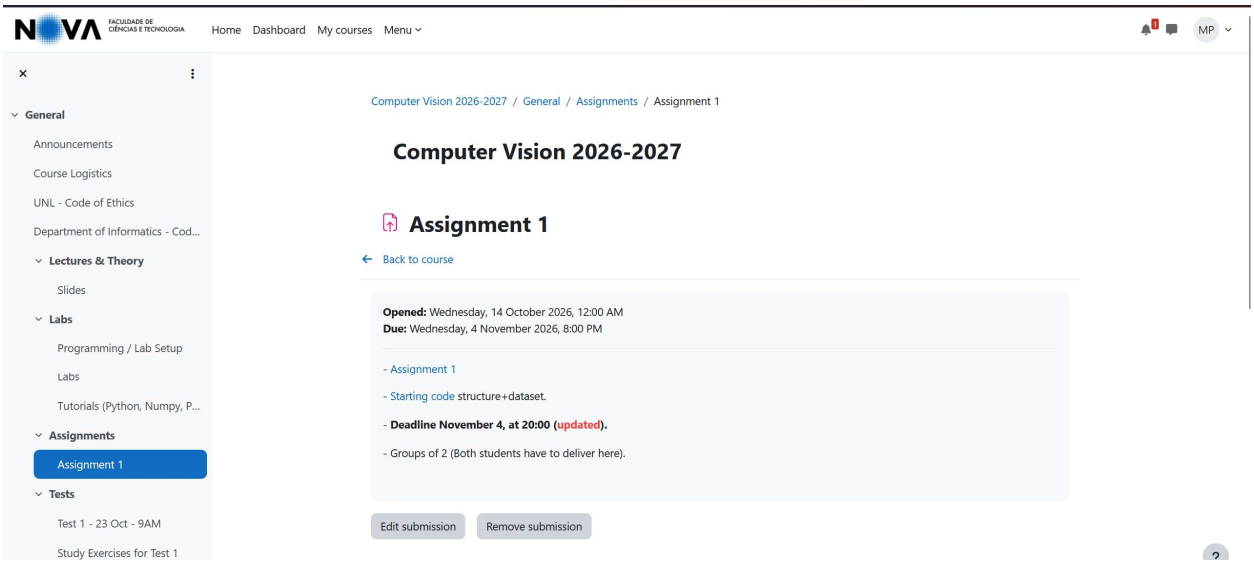
Why it is good

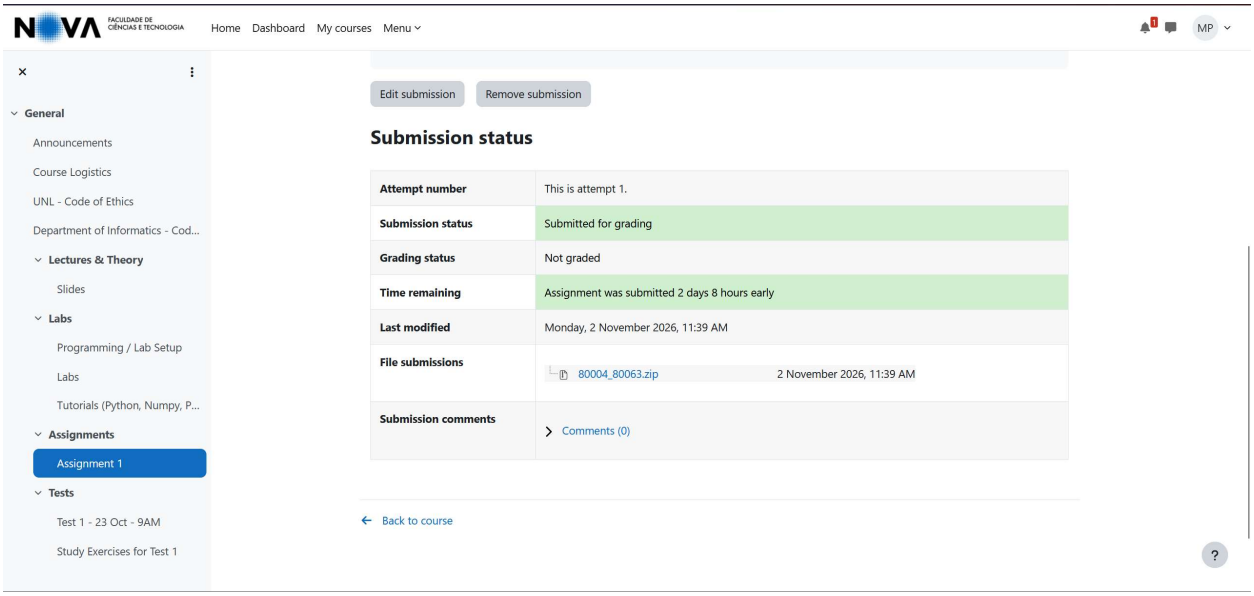
- The status table answers "have I submitted?" and "how much time do I have?" without effort. This is exactly what a student needs at hand-in time.
- After saving, the page shows the new status and the file name, which removes the worry of "did it really go through?".
- Content is grouped and marked with type icons, so students recognise what they are looking for instead of remembering where it is.
- Organising by weeks follows the course calendar, and "assignment", "forum" and "calendar" are concepts students already know.
- A submission can be edited until the deadline, which gives security and lowers the cost of mistakes.
- Drag and drop avoids menus and unnecessary steps, and the calendar collects deadlines that would otherwise be scattered.
- The same page pattern repeats in every course, so learning one means learning all.

As a limitation, the look depends a lot on the theme and on how each teacher organises their page; some pages are long, unstructured lists of files. Much of the good result comes from the patterns the platform provides.


Home
Dashboard
My courses
Menu
MP
My courses
Course overview
All
Search
Sort by course name
Card
Computer Vision 2026-2027
1º Semestre
gab.ip.helpdesk@fct.unl.pt | 212 949 654 | 15508
Moodle 4.5.12+ (Build: 20260728)


Home
Dashboard
My courses
Menu
MP
General
Announcements
Course Logistics
UNL - Code of Ethics
Department of Informatics - Cod...
Lectures & Theory
Slides
Labs
Programming / Lab Setup
Labs
Tutorials (Python, Numpy, P...
Assignments
Assignment 1
Tests
Test 1 - 23 Oct - 9AM
Study Exercises for Test 1
Computer Vision 2026-2027
Course
Participants
Grades
Competencies
More
General
Collapse all
Announcements
Course Logistics
Lecturer:
David Semedo <df.semedo@fct.unl.pt>
Office: Gab. 243 Ed.II
Office hours: Mondays, 10:00-11:00
** Please email the lecturer at least 24 hours in advance if you plan to attend office hours. **
Discord Link: https://discord.gg/QqxgyRbSEF
Pre-course Questionnaire: https://forms.gle/AKtTPjqgfotqS4aD6
UNL - Code of Ethics





Bad example: navigation and feedback in CLIP

Objective of the interface

CLIP is the academic management system of NOVA FCT. According to the faculty's enrolment guide, it is where students find timetables, exams, course units and requests, among other things. It is also used for enrolment and payments. This analysis does not cover the whole system, only two aspects: **navigation** (how a student reaches the function they need) and **feedback** (how the system responds to a click).

Bad aspects

- **A home page that only covers personal data.** After login, the home page (Figure 1) shows three small boxes ("Dados Pessoais", "Candidato", "Aluno"). The only expanded menu is about the student's personal data (identification, tax number, contacts, authentication, vehicles) and the rest of the page is empty. To deal with anything related to the school itself, the student has to

click the student number ("80063 (MEI)") inside the "Aluno" box. That link looks like plain italic text, so nothing signals that it is the way in.

- **A second page made of nested menus.** The page that opens (Figure 2) shows six columns of menus ("Acto administrativo", "Acto curricular", "Situação Académica", "Ano lectivo", "Informação Geral", "Reserva de espaços"). Menus open inside menus: for example, "Acto curricular" leads to "Inscrição", then "Requerimento ao Coordenador", then "2026/27", then "Anual", "1.º S.", "2.º S." and the trimesters. The page is so long that it runs past the bottom of the screen.
- **Links that behave like buttons, with no feedback.** The "buttons" are links. After a click nothing changes on screen to say that the click was received, and the system is slow to respond, so the student does not know whether to wait or to click again.
- **Mixed visual styles and unclear hierarchy.** Headings are sans-serif on teal, some links are sans-serif italics and others are serif italics, there are dark teal sub-menus, a yellow notice box, and similar-looking links with different functions. Everything has similar weight, so nothing stands out. The top bar has unlabelled controls ("+", "»") and a "...atalhos..." drop-down whose purpose is not clear.
- **The same layout everywhere.** The same menu-in-menu structure repeats in all areas, so learning one area does not make any area easier to read.
- **Not responsive.** On a phone the page is a shrunk copy of the desktop layout: text becomes so small that parts are unreadable without zooming.

Why it is bad

- **Visibility of system status:** there is no sign that a click was registered, and slow responses make the problem worse. The student cannot tell the system's state.
- **Poor signifiers and affordances:** the key link (the student number) does not look clickable or important, and the links styled as text do not look like buttons.
- **Recognition rather than recall:** the student has to remember which of the six columns and which sub-level holds a function (for example, where to find the timetable or a request).
- **Match with the real world:** labels such as "Acto administrativo", "Acto curricular" or "Requerimentos @nline" follow the faculty's administrative vocabulary and not what the student wants to do ("see my timetable", "ask for a document").
- **Aesthetic and minimalist design:** many items shown at once, in different styles, hide the few that matter. The year lists (2026/27, 2025/26, ...) repeat in several menus and add more noise.
- **Consistency:** different fonts and link styles for similar things, while the identical layout is used for very different areas.
- **Accessibility and cross-platform use:** small text and a fixed desktop layout exclude the most common way of using a device today.
- **Learning cost:** new students need guides and help from colleagues to find their way, so the interface is not self-explanatory.

One detail is done well: the green "Inscrito" box in Figure 2 clearly shows the student's enrolment status at a glance. This kind of clear status is what the rest of the interface lacks.

Why was it probably designed this way?

- **An old system that kept growing:** the visual style and the use of plain links point to a system designed for desktop browsers many years ago. New features were added to the existing structure without redesigning the whole.
- **Focus on function rather than experience:** the main goal was to give services and students access to administrative processes, and usability was secondary.
- **Menus follow the organisation, not the student:** the structure mirrors the faculty's services and procedures.
- **Captive users:** students cannot choose another system, so there is little competitive pressure to improve it.
- **Cost and risk:** redesigning a system that handles enrolments, grades and payments is expensive and risky, and the priority is that it keeps working.

Suggested improvements

1. **A home page with school tasks, not only personal data:** show today's timetable, upcoming exams and deadlines, pending requests and open payments, with the enrolment status already visible.
2. **Clear signifiers and feedback:** style the main entry points as real buttons, add hover and pressed states, and show a loading indicator or disable the control as soon as it is clicked.
3. **Menus organised around student tasks,** with simple names ("Timetable", "Courses", "Requests", "Payments"), at most two levels, and the nested year lists replaced by a single year selector.
4. **One consistent visual style:** a single typeface, one link style, and stronger emphasis for notices and deadlines.
5. **Responsive design,** so that text is readable on a phone without zooming, at least for the timetable, notices and grades.
6. **Global search,** to go straight to a function or a course.
7. **Usability tests with real students** before releasing changes.

Illustration

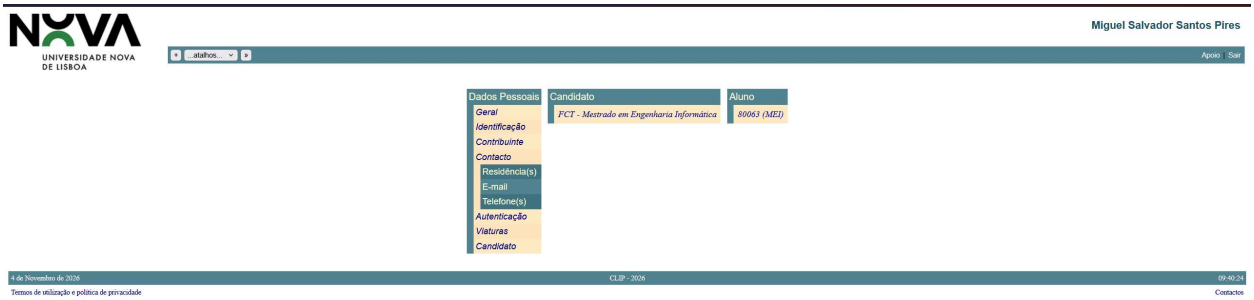


Figure 1: CLIP home page, which only offers personal data; school-related functions are reached through the student number inside the "Aluno" box.

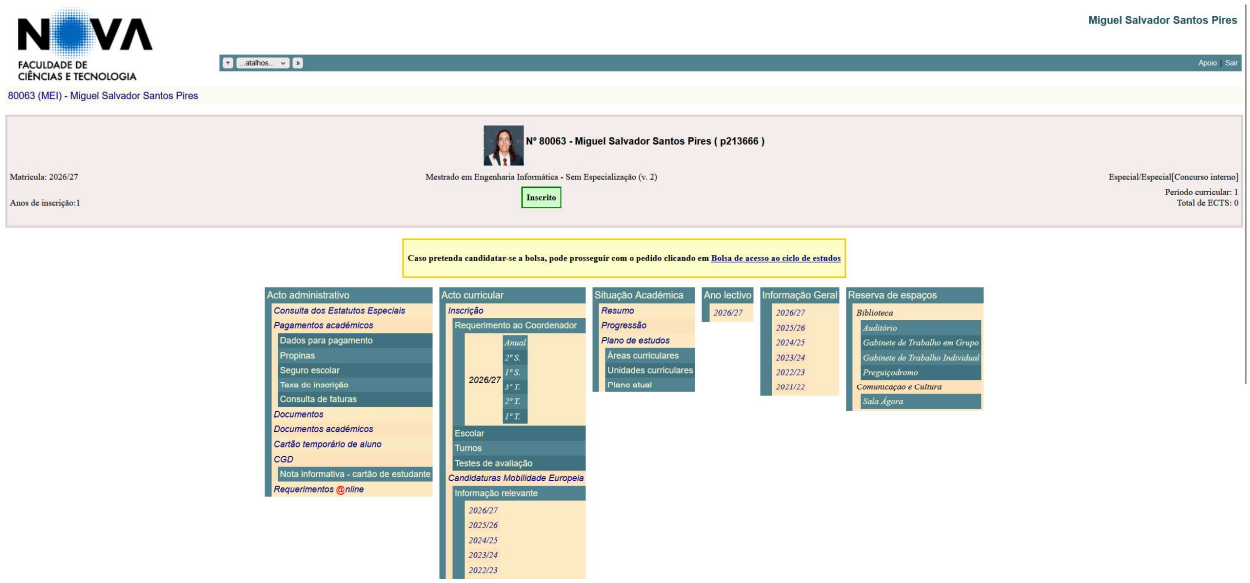


Figure 2: the page behind that link, with six columns of nested menus.

Conclusion

Moodle and CLIP are used by the same students, with the same credentials, and they show two opposite approaches. Moodle organises information around the student's tasks and always shows the state of what is happening (for example, the submission of an assignment). CLIP organises it around the faculty's services and forces students to remember where each function is. The difference is not in the features but in how the interface communicates what can be done and where the user currently is.

Sources

- Enrolment guide 2025/26, NOVA FCT: description of CLIP and of the path to the course pages.
- Moodle@FCT, course access: login with CLIP credentials.